

Astrarium Pro — User Manual

For version 1.3

7 September 2026

- [Contents](#)
- [1. Introduction](#)
 - [1.1 Requirements](#)
 - [1.2 First steps](#)
- [2. The screen](#)
 - [2.1 The top bar](#)
 - [2.2 The signature line](#)
- [3. Choosing where you are](#)
- [4. Driving the chart](#)
 - [4.1 All-sky and horizon views](#)
 - [4.2 Gestures](#)
 - [4.3 What a tap tells you](#)
- [5. Moving through time](#)
 - [5.1 Steps and playback](#)
 - [5.2 Grids](#)
- [6. What the chart shows](#)
 - [6.1 The quick bar](#)
 - [6.2 The View tab \(\$\equiv \rightarrow\$ View\)](#)
 - [6.3 Export as PNG or PDF](#)
 - [6.4 Demo and recording](#)
- [7. Meteor showers](#)
 - [7.1 The list](#)
 - [7.2 How the rate is worked out](#)
- [8. Comets and asteroids](#)
- [9. Events](#)
- [10. The Info tab](#)
- [11. The Pro features](#)
 - [11.1 Satellites](#)
 - [11.2 AR](#)
 - [11.3 Aurora forecast](#)
 - [11.4 The proper-motion time machine](#)
 - [11.5 The deep catalogue \(more stars at telescope fields\)](#)
 - [11.6 Telling satellites apart](#)
 - [11.7 The solar system in 3D](#)

- [11.8 Two more kinds of event](#)
- [12. If something looks wrong](#)
- [13. Glossary](#)
- [14. Credits and contact](#)



Contents

1. Introduction
2. The screen
3. Choosing where you are
4. Driving the chart
5. Moving through time
6. What the chart shows
7. Meteor showers
8. Comets and asteroids
9. Events
10. The Info tab
11. The Pro features
12. If something looks wrong
13. Glossary
14. Credits and contact

1. Introduction

Astrarium Pro is a planisphere and astronomical simulator for iPhone and iPad. It shows the sky as it is now, but it also lets you drive the clock freely — back into the past, forward into the future — and it puts planetary phases, eclipses, meteor showers and comets on the same chart.

It also does satellites (the space stations, the naked-eye satellites, science satellites, Starlink, the weather satellites and Japan's geostationary fleet), AR (the chart drawn over the live camera) and the aurora forecast (chapter 11). Everything else is the same screen, and the same handling, as the free Astrarium.

Positions come from the JPL DE421 ephemeris, the IAU precession and nutation models and IERS Earth-orientation data, and are accurate enough to plan real observing sessions with.

1.1 Requirements

Devices	iPhone / iPad (iOS and iPadOS 17.0 or later)
Orientation	Portrait and landscape both supported
Price	Paid. No advertising
Network	The chart and all the astronomy run on the device — it works offline
Data collection	None. Your site and settings stay on the device

An internet connection is needed only to **update** four things:

- satellite orbital elements (TLEs, from Celestrak),
- the aurora forecast (NASA DONKI, NOAA OVATION),
- comet and asteroid elements (from the MPC and JPL),
- your current position (this uses location services, not the network). Where Precise Location is switched off, the app asks for it once, for that single fix: an approximate position can be kilometres out, and that changes what is visible near the horizon.

1.2 First steps

1. On launch, the app shows the sky over Tokyo at the present moment.
2. Press  in the top bar and allow the use of your location. Astrarium switches to your position and tells you the nearest registered site and how far away it is. If you would rather not share your location, pick a site from the list or type in coordinates (chapter 3).
3. Outdoors, press  (night vision). The whole interface turns red so that it does not spoil your dark adaptation.

2. The screen

The screen is divided into five bands, from top to bottom.

Band	Where	What it does
Top bar	Top	Clock, observing site, location, panel, language, night vision
Chart	Middle	The sky itself — driven with your fingers
Quick bar	Below the chart	Magnitude slider and the common toggles (two rows)
Time bar	Below that	How the sky is shown (all-sky, horizon, AR, aurora) and the grids; moving and playing the clock (three rows)
Signature	Bottom	Logo and author, both links

The three rows of the time bar are, from the top,

1. **All-sky / Horizon / AR / Aurora / Grids** — how the sky is shown
2. **–syn –1d –1h –1m / +1m +1h +1d +syn** — moving the clock
3. **Date button / time / Now / ◀ ■ ▶** — the date and time themselves

Pressing the date button opens a calendar; the time field can be typed into.

The two lower bars fold away, in either of two ways:

- **Press the triangle (▼)** just above them; press again to bring them back. The arrow says which way things move (▼ folds down, ▲ brings back).
- **Take hold of a bar itself and drag it up or down.** Past halfway it folds; the triangle pulls it back. Take hold between the controls rather than on a button or slider, so that the ordinary controls keep working.

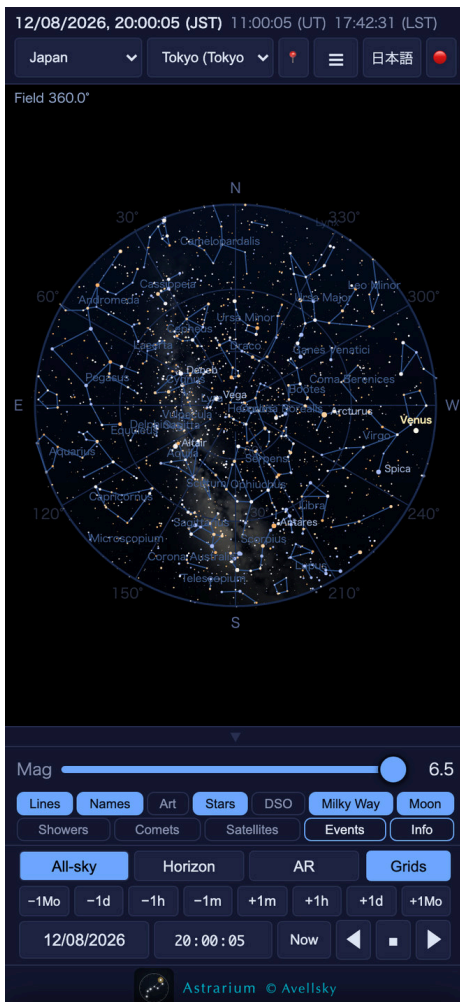


Figure 1. The all-sky view (Tokyo, 12 August 2026, 20:00)

2.1 The top bar

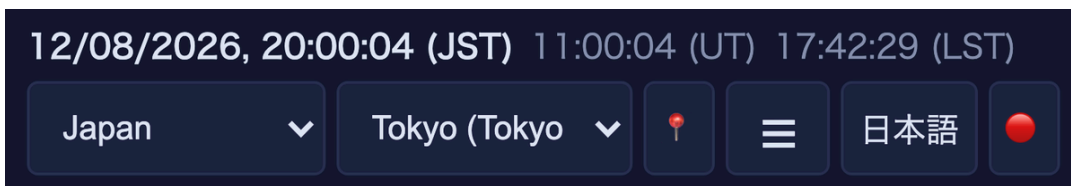


Figure 2. The top bar: site category and site, location, panel, language, night vision

- **Clock** — local time at the observing site and Universal Time (UT), side by side.
- **Site category** — Japan (the 47 prefectural capitals), Japanese dark-sky sites, observatories, aurora viewing sites, major cities other than capitals, the capitals of each continent, and the Antarctic research stations. Observatories at home and abroad are one list. Each menu is named for exactly what is in it: “Asia · capitals” holds one national capital per country. Choosing observatories adds a second **Region** menu so you can narrow the list down by continent.

- **Site** — the place itself. The prefectures and the dark-sky sites run north to south; the world cities are alphabetical, by the reading of the name when the app is in Japanese.
-  — use your current position.
-  — open or close the detail panel.
- **EN / 日本語** — switch language. Object names, constellation names and every description change with it.
-  — night vision; press again to return to normal colours.

2.2 The signature line

The logo at the bottom opens the Astrarium Pro home page and © Ave11sky opens the author's page, both in the browser.

3. Choosing where you are

Pick a place from the category and site menus in the top bar, or press  to open the **site screen**, which holds a map, coordinate entry and your saved places on one panel.

Pick it from the list

Use the category and site menus in the top bar. The app carries the capital of each of the 47 Japanese prefectures — “Sapporo (Hokkaido)”, named with its prefecture — recommended dark-sky sites in Japan ordered by prefecture from the north, every national capital named with its country, the major cities that are not capitals, the Antarctic research stations, and the world's observatories with their MPC codes. Each place appears in one menu only. **Aurora viewing sites** collects the places people go to see the aurora (23 of them): Fairbanks, Yellowknife, Tromsø, Abisko, Rovaniemi, Akureyri and Longyearbyen in the north, Hobart, Invercargill and Ushuaia in the south, and two in Japan — the Nayoro and Rikubetsu observatories. The bracket after each name is **the country**: Japan comes first, then the countries in order, and the places within a country by name.

Open the site screen

Press . Nothing moves the moment you press it.

- **Get current position** — choose “While Using the App” when iOS asks. If Precise Location is off, the app asks once for the precise fix (an approximate one can be kilometres out, which changes what sits on the horizon). Tick “Get position at launch” and it will do this on every start.

- **Map** — drag the map (OpenStreetMap) until the centre mark is on the spot; + and – zoom.
- **Latitude, longitude, altitude** — type degrees, minutes and seconds, and the altitude; the arrows step one unit at a time. “Use this position” applies it.
- **List** — save up to **ten** places by name and tap a row to go there.

Changing the site updates the clock, the rise and set times and the whole geometry of the chart together.

4. Driving the chart

4.1 All-sky and horizon views

Switch with **All-sky** and **Horizon** at the left of the time bar.

- **All-sky** — the whole sky as a circle centred on the zenith, north up and east to the left, exactly as on a cardboard planisphere. The Milky Way is drawn in this view.
- **Horizon** — part of the sky drawn as you would actually see it looking out. The menu beside the button chooses which way you face: **N**, **E**, **S**, **W**.

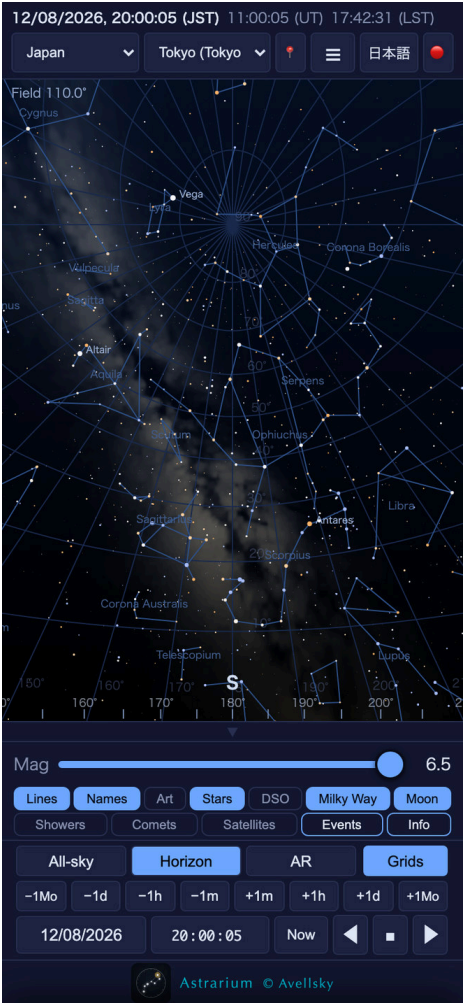


Figure 3. Horizon view, facing south, 110-degree field

4.2 Gestures

Gesture	All-sky	Horizon
One-finger drag	Diurnal rotation — the sky turns about the celestial pole and the clock follows your finger	Pans the view
Two-finger pinch	Zoom about the point between your fingers	The same
Double tap	Recentre on the zenith	—
Tap an object	Opens its information popup	The same
Mouse wheel	Zoom	Zoom
SHIFT + drag	Pans the view centre without rotating	—

Dragging in all-sky view is the planisphere gesture: the dial turns and the simulated time turns with it, so you can feel out how high Orion will be in two hours' time with a fingertip.

4.3 What a tap tells you

The popup gives the name, right ascension and declination, azimuth and altitude and the magnitude, with buttons underneath. **The readings follow the clock while the card is open.** Azimuth and altitude are recomputed twice a second, α and δ , distance, elongation and phase angle each time the sky is refreshed, and the rise, transit and set times when the local date turns over. “(below the horizon)” is added once the object has set.

The Sun, the Moon, the planets and the moons drawn in the zoom view also carry a sentence or two on what they are, and every card gives the **distance** — in astronomical units for the solar system (kilometres for the Moon) and in light years for the stars, from the Hipparcos parallaxes.

Close a card with the **pin (📌)** in its **top-right corner**. Tapping the body of the card does not close it, so a long description can be read without it vanishing under your finger.



Figure 4. Saturn tapped: coordinates, magnitude, rise and set, and two buttons

-  **Zoom in** — puts the object in the middle of the screen, zooms in and starts **tracking** it. While tracking, the object stays centred as the clock runs. Release it with the **Release** button on the chart or the `Esc` key; panning the view does not break the tracking.
-  **Details** (Sun, Moon and planets) — opens a window that draws the body as a disc, recomputed every five seconds so its distance, elongation, phase angle and libration follow the clock too. The figures include the **physical data** — diameter, mass, mean density, rotation period, axial tilt and surface gravity — and scroll inside the window when there are more than it can show.
-  **Polar alignment** (Polaris only) — opens the polar scope's field, with Polaris on an hour-angle ring that follows the clock. The red button in that window switches night vision on and off. The Moon comes with its age, illuminated fraction, libration and popular name (Pink Moon, supermoon and so on); Jupiter with the four Galilean moons; Saturn with the rings and Titan; Mars with Phobos and Deimos. You can drag inside the window.



Figure 5. The zoom view of Saturn, with the rings and its moons

Picking a deep-sky object brings up a photograph and a short description; a comet or asteroid brings up its orbital elements and estimated brightness; a satellite brings up its range, height and apparent magnitude with a **Next visible passes** button. Deep-sky names, constellations and descriptions are available in both languages; an object with no Japanese name is listed by its catalogue number in Japanese, with the English name beside it.

Tapping a meteor shower's radiant gives its azimuth and altitude as well as its coordinates, and these follow the clock — so you can see at a glance whether the radiant is up yet.

With constellation art switched on, tapping one of the twelve zodiacal constellations shows the corresponding astrological sign and its birth dates, together with a note that precession has moved the signs about a month away from where the Sun really is.



Figure 6. The whole sky with the constellation figures drawn

5. Moving through time

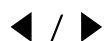
The lower two rows of the time bar do this.

5.1 Steps and playback

Control	What it does
–syn / +syn	Back or forward one synodic month (29.53 days) — the same lunar phase
–1d / –1h / –1m	Back one day, hour or minute
+1m / +1h / +1d	Forward one minute, hour or day
Date button	Opens a calendar. Picking a day keeps the time of day and moves the date
Time field	Type 21:30 and the clock goes to that time on the same day
Now	Return to the present

Control

What it does



Play backward / forward; each press steps $\times 1 \rightarrow \times 60 \rightarrow \times 600 \rightarrow \times 6000$ and round again



Hold the clock still; press again and it runs from where it stopped

Rate

The speed it is running at — “stopped” when held, “real time” when idle

While it runs the arrow carries the rate in its heads: $\blacktriangleright \times 1$, $\blacktriangleright\blacktriangleright \times 60$, $\blacktriangleright\blacktriangleright\blacktriangleright \times 600$, $\blacktriangleright\blacktriangleright\blacktriangleright\blacktriangleright \times 6000$, and a minus sign on the rate when running backwards. At $\times 600$ one second of yours is ten minutes of sky.

■ also detaches the chart from real time. Idle, the sky still moves at the rate the real sky moves; **■** stops it dead. Stepping the clock still works while it is held, and it stays wherever you step it to.

With a keyboard, $\leftarrow$ and $\rightarrow$ move ± 10 minutes, with `shift` ± 1 day, with `Alt` ± 1 minute, and $\uparrow$ $\downarrow$ move ± 1 hour.

Every date and time is the time at the observing site. Choose a site abroad and the clock, the date button and the time field all switch to that place’s time — not the device’s. The zone abbreviation (JST, GMT and so on) follows the clock in brackets.

In the horizon view the altitude lines run all the way to **90° (the zenith)**, numbered like the rest. In the whole-sky view 90° is a point, not a line.

5.2 Grids

The **Grids** button opens a menu of overlays; you can have several at once.

Overlay

What it is

Alt-Az grid

Horizontal coordinates — azimuth and altitude

RA-Dec grid

Equatorial coordinates, the system star catalogues use

Ecliptic grid

Ecliptic coordinates; the planets and the Moon keep to this band

Galactic grid

Galactic coordinates; the Milky Way lies along latitude 0°

Celestial equator

Drawn as a single great circle

Overlay

Ecliptic

Galactic plane

Meridian

What it is

The Sun's path, likewise

The great circle at galactic latitude 0° — the centre line of the Milky Way

The north–south great circle objects transit

The spacing of the lines and the precision of the labels follow the zoom level.

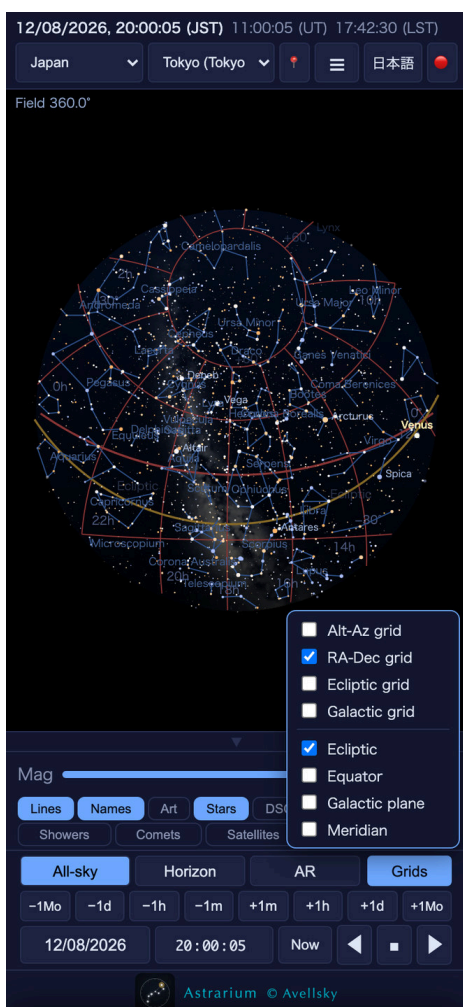


Figure 7. The grid menu, with the RA-Dec grid and the ecliptic drawn

6. What the chart shows

6.1 The quick bar

The slider on the left is the **magnitude limit**. Lower it and the faint stars go, which is much closer to a city sky; raise it and the chart goes to magnitude 6.5, the naked-eye limit.

The first row controls the chart itself, the second the kinds of object.

Button	Shows
Lines	The figures of the 88 constellations
Names	Constellation names
Art	Constellation drawings (86 of them; shown whatever the magnitude limit)
Stars	Names of the named stars
DSO	Messier and Caldwell objects
Milky Way	The Milky Way — drawn in the all-sky view, unbroken down to the horizon
Moon	Sky brightness from moonlight
Showers	Radiants and expected rates of the active meteor showers (chapter 7)
Comets	Every comet currently bright enough (fetches elements the first time)
Satellites	Satellites on the chart (fetches TLEs the first time; chapter 11)
Events	Opens the Events tab
Info	Opens the Info tab

AR, in the first row of the time bar, draws the chart over the camera image, and **Aurora** opens the aurora forecast (chapter 11).

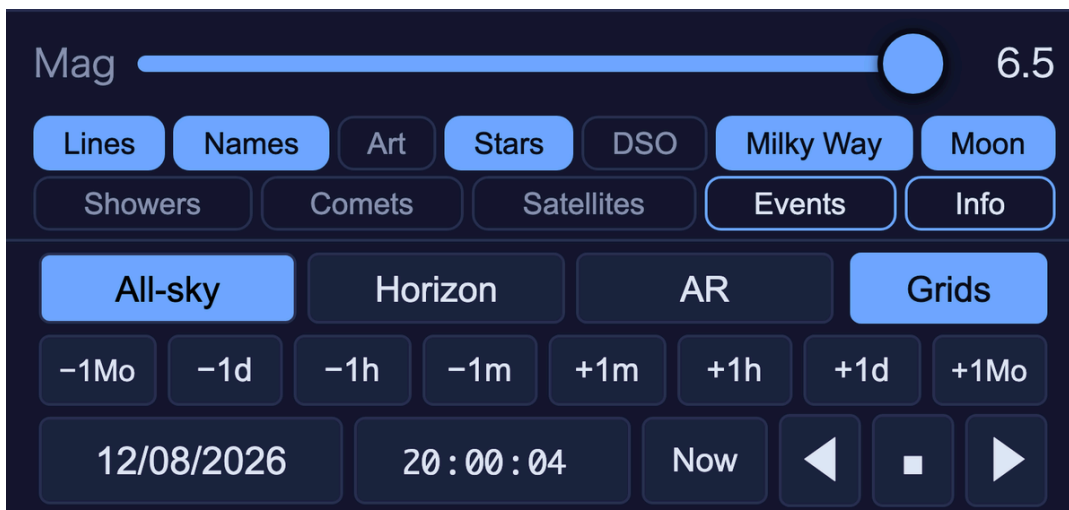


Figure 8. The quick bar and the time bar

6.2 The View tab ($\equiv \rightarrow$ View)

Everything the quick bar does not carry lives here.

- **Sun, Moon & planets** — show or hide them.

- **Stars** — show or hide the stars. Switch them off and the constellation lines stand on their own. A star is drawn in the colour of the temperature implied by its own **measured colour index (B–V)**, not a stock colour per spectral class, so two red stars such as Aldebaran and Betelgeuse are not the same red.
- **Sunlight** — daylight and twilight. Switch it off to draw the sky as if it were always dark, which is how you check where the stars are in the daytime.
- **Moonlight** — the wash of a bright Moon. It switches separately from sunlight, so you can leave the daytime sky as it is and take out only the moonlight to see what the stars would do.
- **Mirror** — flips the image for a telescope finder that inverts.
- **Star trails** — leaves a trail behind moving objects during playback, so diurnal motion and satellite passes are drawn as lines.
- **Long exposure** — keeps the trails instead of letting them fade, so the tracks build up as they would on film (switching it on switches trails on too).
- **FOV frames** — rectangles for a camera field or circles for an eyepiece, laid over the chart. “Add frame”, then give it a sensor size and focal length, or an apparent field and a magnification. Drag the centre to move the frame, click the centre to zoom to it, drag a corner to rotate. Useful for framing a photograph, or for seeing what will fit in the field.
- **Mag limit** — the same slider as on the quick bar.

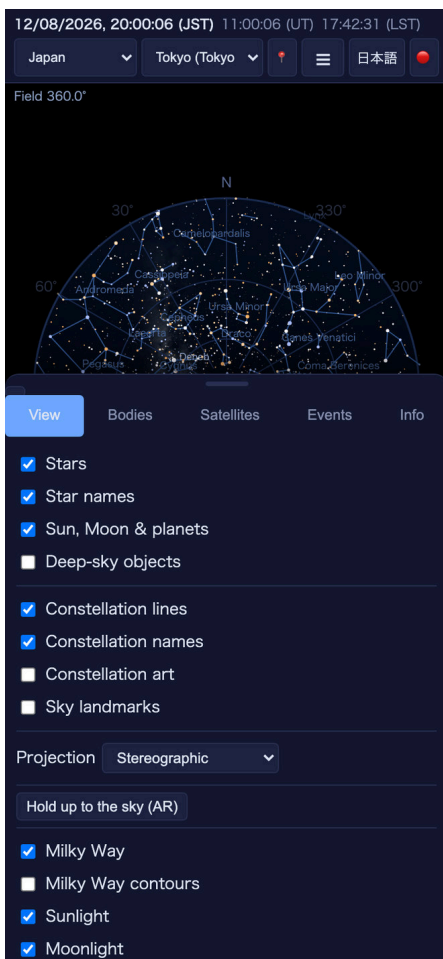


Figure 9. The View tab

6.3 Export as PNG or PDF

Saves the chart for the current time and site as an image. Because these are meant to be printed and taken outside:

- the background is white paper and the stars and lines are black,
- sky brightness (sunlight and moonlight) is left out,
- the Milky Way is drawn **as contours only**, not filled,
- the date, time and Astrarium Pro © Avellsky appear in the bottom right corner.

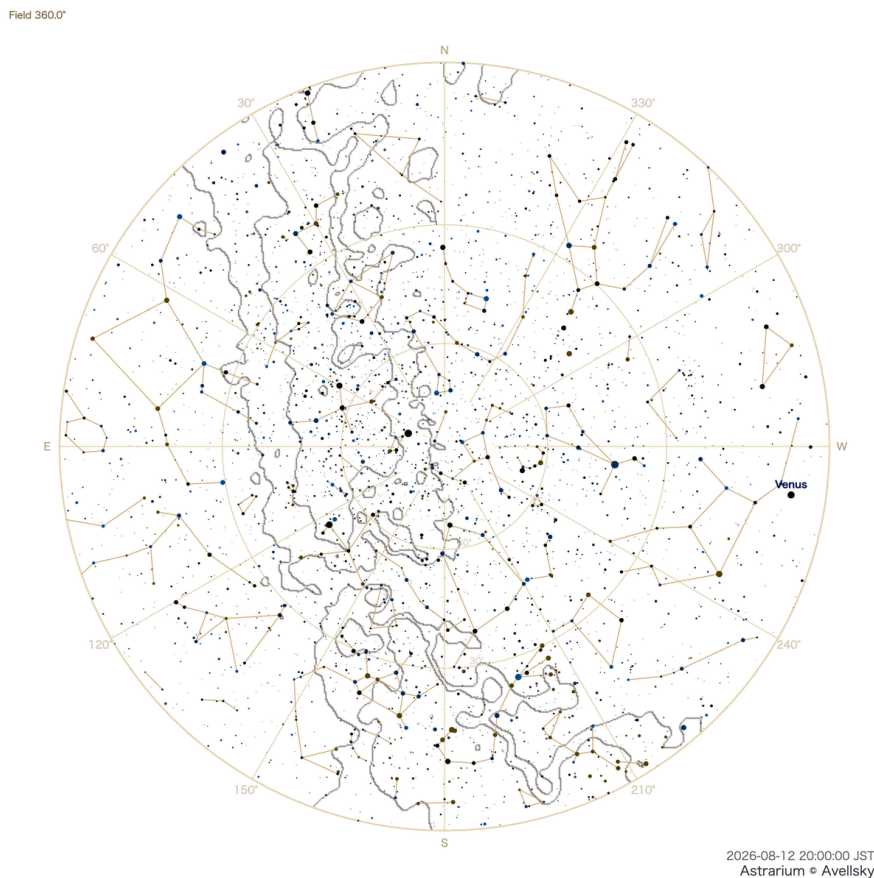


Figure 10. An exported chart: the Milky Way drawn as contours on white paper

6.4 Demo and recording

Demo is a tour of a few minutes. It plays without sound; each scene is described in captions below the chart. It runs through twilight, the Milky Way and moonlight, the apparent size of a planet, Saturn's rings and moons, FOV frames, the Moon's libration, deep-sky objects with photographs, a meteor shower, a long exposure, the language switch and diurnal motion. Touching the screen ends the tour and restores what you had.

It takes a moment to get ready before the first scene appears — a note under the button says so. While it runs, the button turns red and reads **Stop demo**, so you can end it at any point.

Record saves the moving chart as a video (if the device cannot do it, the button says so). Start recording during the demo and the file saves itself when the tour ends.

7. Meteor showers

Use the **Bodies** tab or the **Showers** button on the quick bar.

7.1 The list

The menu holds the principal showers of the year, sorted by **how close their maximum is to the date on the chart**. Choosing one moves the clock to **the moment of that maximum** and opens the details; where the maximum falls in daylight, it moves to about 1 a.m. that night instead. Clicking the radiant on the chart itself leaves the clock where it is.

Field	Meaning
Maximum	In Japanese, the local time of your site (JST for a site in Japan); in every other language, Universal Time (UT)
Radiant	Right ascension and declination, with its altitude at maximum and now
Entry speed	How fast the meteoroids meet the atmosphere
Population index r	The proportion of bright meteors; the smaller, the brighter
Parent body	The comet or asteroid the stream came from
Expected rate	Meteors per hour, from the model below

7.2 How the rate is worked out

The figure in “per hour” is not the ideal ZHR — it is **what you can expect from your site at that moment**. Four factors are multiplied together:

1. **Distance from the maximum.** A Gaussian profile: about a day either side the rate has fallen to the sporadic background, and outside the activity period nothing is shown at all.
2. **Radiant altitude.** The lower the radiant, the fewer meteors; below the horizon, none.
3. **Twilight.** Zero between sunrise and sunset, reduced during twilight in proportion to how bright the sky is.
4. **Moonlight.** Reduced according to the Moon's phase and altitude.

Active showers are also listed in an orange box at the top of the chart. Tapping a name in the box opens its details; **Release** clears the box (and turns off the Showers button on the quick bar with it).

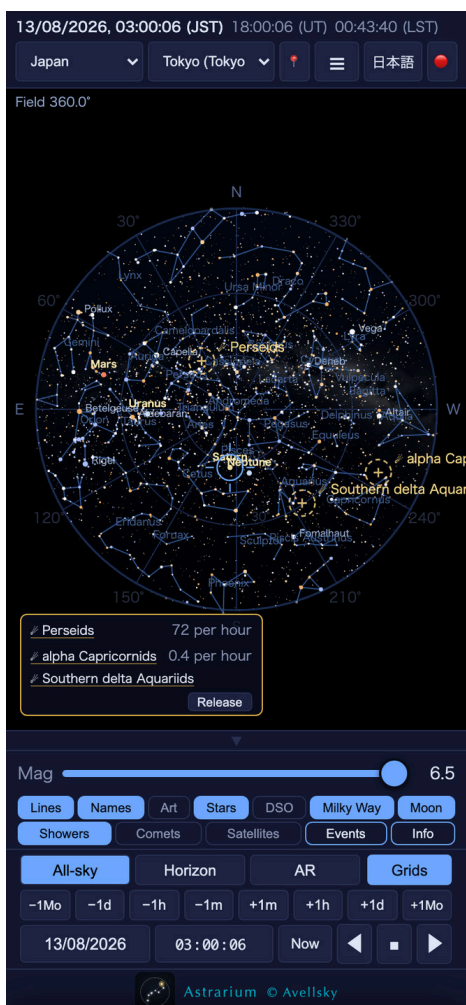


Figure 11. The Perseid maximum (13 August, 3 a.m., 72 per hour expected)

8. Comets and asteroids

The lower half of the **Bodies** tab.

- **List bright now** — the comets and asteroids in the sky, brightest first.

- **Search** — by any part of a name or designation. If the object is not in the local data, Astrarium asks JPL for it and adds it (needs a connection).
- **All / Comets / Asteroids** — filters the list.
- **Selected** — the objects drawn on the chart. Anything you put here is plotted.
- **Update from MPC** — fresh comet elements from the Minor Planet Center and asteroid elements from JPL. The date of the last fetch is shown underneath.

Tapping a comet on the chart gives its distance from the Sun and from the Earth, phase angle, estimated diameter, orbital elements, period and epoch.

9. Events

The **Events** tab lists eclipses, oppositions and conjunctions, solstices and equinoxes, meteor maxima, close approaches of the Moon and planets, and occultations.

- **Period** — what is next, 1 day, 7 days, 30, 90 or 180 days, 1, 5 or 10 years. “What is next” looks up to 90 days ahead and shows **the next event only**.
- **Direction** — upcoming, past, or both (fixed to upcoming for “what is next”). **Choosing past or both drops the kinds that are only ever predicted forwards** — occultations and satellite passes — from the Kind menu.
- **Kind** — one at a time:
 - **All astronomical events** — eclipses, oppositions, conjunctions and stations, the solstices and equinoxes, the Moon’s phases, perigee and apogee, the meteor maxima.
 - **Occultations** — the Moon passing in front of a star, with immersion or emersion, dark or bright limb, and the star’s magnitude.
 - **Naked-eye satellites** — visible passes of the ISS, the CSS and the Starlink trains.
 - **Eclipses** — with local circumstances (magnitude and times for your site). The last three list only what can actually be observed from your site — above the horizon and in a dark enough sky. Where nothing qualifies, the tab says how many fell in daylight or below the horizon. “All astronomical events” is not filtered.
-  **Search** starts the scan. While it runs the button reads “🕒 searching 12s — press to stop” and pressing it does stop; the list below is dimmed so that the previous answer is not mistaken for this one.
- Tap a row and **the chart jumps to that moment**; the panel closes so the chart is in front of you.

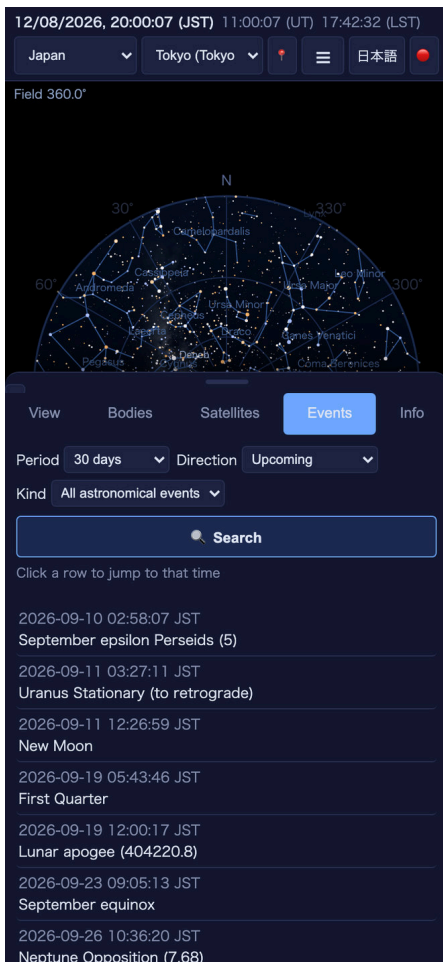


Figure 12. The Events tab

10. The Info tab

- **The sky for the date and place you have chosen** — sunset and sunrise, the beginning and end of twilight, the dark window, moonrise, moonset and lunar age, the transits of the Sun and Moon, the traditional lunisolar date and solar term, and local sidereal time. The heading names them both — “Tokyo — 22 August 2026” — and moving the clock to another date changes the table with it.
- **Selected object** — the position and rise/set times of whatever you last tapped on the chart.
- **Credits and sources** — every catalogue, ephemeris, image and library the app uses, with its source, its licence and the date it was last checked. It follows the language setting.

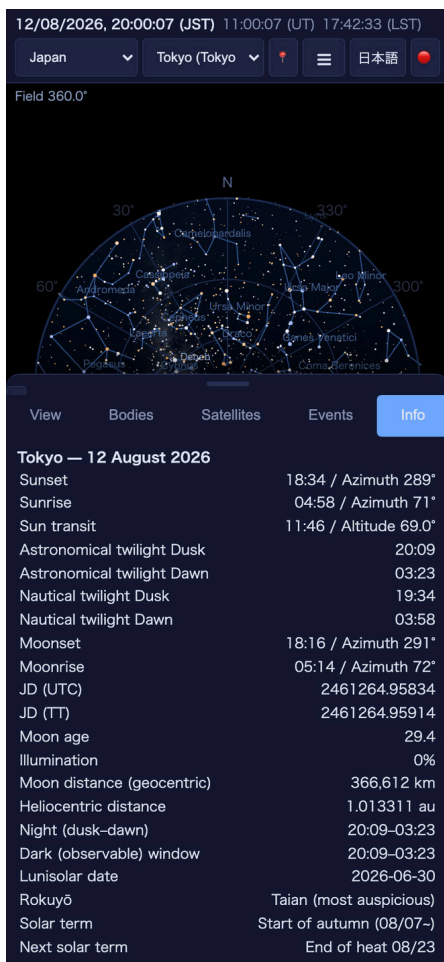


Figure 13. The Info tab, “Tonight’s sky”

11. The Pro features

These are what the free Astrarium does not have. There, satellites are the space stations only, and there is no aurora forecast and no proper-motion time machine.

Three of them now sit together under the “PRO” tab in ≡ — the aurora forecast, the solar-system map and the proper-motion time machine, one tab to the right of **Bodies**. They used to be scattered between the bottom of the view tab and a tab of their own; now there is one place to look. Satellites and AR stay where they were (the **Satellites** tab and the time bar).

11.1 Satellites

The **Satellites** tab, or the **Satellites** button on the quick bar.

1. Press **Download / update TLEs** first (this needs a connection). Within two hours of a fetch it answers “up to date” rather than asking again. Several groups are fetched at once, so the wait is the slowest one, not the sum. The

elapsed seconds are shown while it runs; with no answer after 25 seconds (60 for Starlink) it stops and says so. Starlink is about 1.7 MB and more than ten thousand objects, and propagating them takes another ten seconds or so.

About the interval. CelesTrak asks callers not to fetch the same group more than once every two hours — that is how often the elements change. Fetching harder returns errors, and persisting gets the address blocked. Astrarium Pro records the time of each fetch and, within two hours, answers from what it already has. That is not thrift; it is how the block is avoided.

2. Switch on **Show on chart** and the satellites start moving across the sky.
3. Choose the groups to show.

Group	What is in it
Space stations	The ISS and Tiangong
Brightest (visual)	The satellites bright enough to see
Science	Research and observation satellites
Starlink	The Starlink constellation
Weather	Meteorological satellites

- **Magnitude limit** — 4 by default, which is roughly what the eye can do.
- **Sunlit only** — show only satellites out of the Earth's shadow, that is, the ones actually visible.
- Tapping a satellite gives its range, height, apparent magnitude and how old its elements are. **Next visible passes** lists the passes for the next five days.
- Above ×600 playback the satellites are paused: the propagation cannot keep up.

Finding a satellite

Search by any part of the name. Nicknames work too — “Hinode”, “XRISM”, “Daichi”, “Himawari”, “Michibiki” are translated to the catalogue name.

- Press a name and **that satellite is selected**: its coming passes and its **current position** (azimuth and altitude, sub-satellite point, height in km, whether it is sunlit) are shown. Even when there is no visible pass for weeks, where it is right now is still answered.
- **With the horizon view on screen, the selected satellite is brought to the centre** and kept there, so a pass that crosses the sky in minutes is not

lost. Panning the chart by hand lets go of it.

- Geostationary satellites (Himawari and the like) are outside the pass prediction. The catalogue entry and NORAD number are shown, with a note.
- + adds it to “My list” for next time.

Projections

The **Projection** menu at the top of the tab shows the same satellites four ways.

Projection

What you see

All-sky	On the zenith-centred chart
Horizon	On the chart as you would look up at it
World map	Equirectangular, with the ground track behind and ahead
Globe	Orthographic Earth, with the day/night terminator

The map and the globe carry **national borders** (the land ones) as well as the coastline.

On the map and the globe the names are **placed so that they do not overlap** (where there is no room, the dot is drawn without a name). Selecting a satellite brings up a card with its **country and flag**, its height and speed, and its next visible pass.

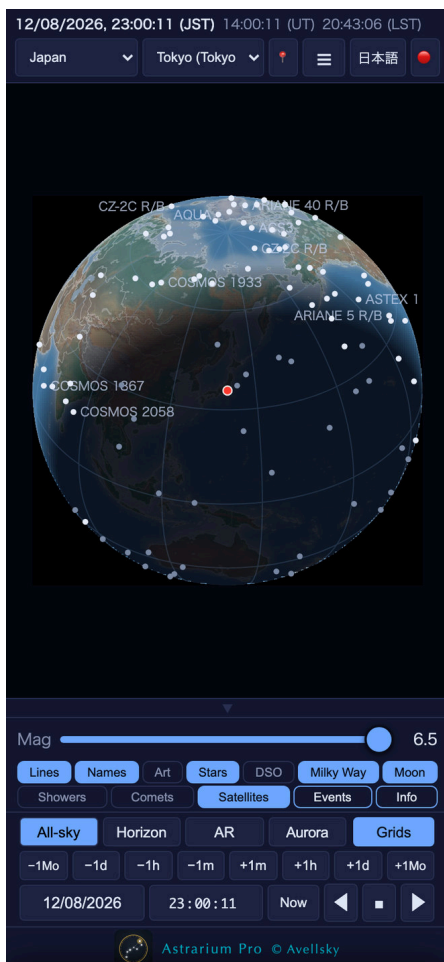


Figure 14. Satellites on the globe

11.2 AR

Press **AR** on the time bar and the chart is drawn over the rear camera image. Hold the device up and the constellations line up with the sky in front of you. The first time, iOS asks for camera and motion permission.

The control panel at the bottom has four rows.

Row	What is on it
1	Field of view and bearing sliders, and night mode
2	What to draw: stars / constellation lines / names / art / landmarks / Milky Way / Sun / Moon and planets / alt-azimuth / RA-Dec / equator / ecliptic
3	The magnitude slider
4	Date and time, Now , Reset , the direction you are pointing, the four

Row

What is on it

shutter buttons (twilight, Moon, stars, aurora) and **Leave AR**

- A button brightens when it is on, so what is being drawn is visible at a glance.
- The **bearing** slider corrects the chart when the compass is off. **Reset** throws the correction away and follows the sensor again.
- **Shutter** composites the camera image and the chart into one picture. The four buttons are exposure settings — the darker the subject, the longer. Keep a little of the landscape in frame, or turn the alt-azimuth grid on, and the direction is still readable afterwards.
- **Leave AR** puts back the display settings you had before AR started.

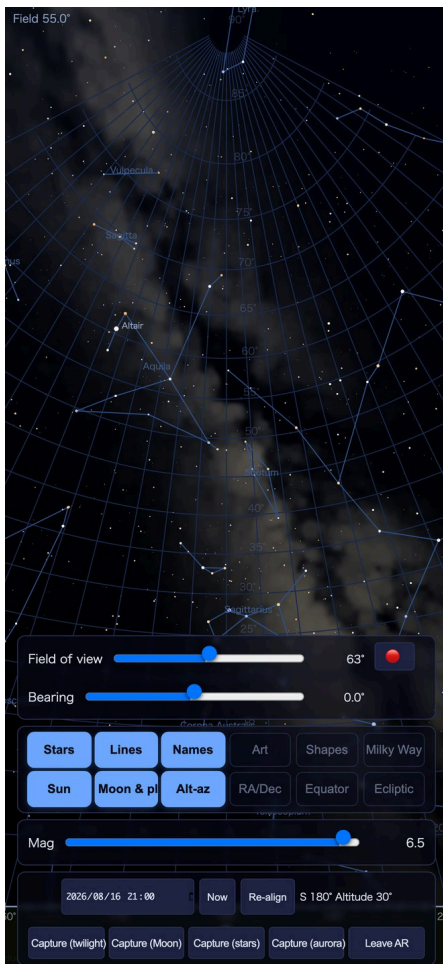


Figure 15. AR: the chart drawn over the camera image

11.3 Aurora forecast

Aurora on the time bar, or $\equiv \rightarrow$ **PRO**.

- **Forecast the aurora** fetches NASA DONKI: the solar-wind arrival prediction (the ENLIL model) and the recent geomagnetic storms (observed Kp).

Needs a connection.

- The **geomagnetic latitude** of your site is given first, with the Kp at which the aurora would clear your horizon.
- **Draw in the sky** puts the auroral oval on the chart (all-sky, horizon) or on the globe.
- The **Kp** slider lets you see what a stronger storm would look like.

How it is drawn: the oval is placed by a dipole approximation of the geomagnetic field, and the height of the emission (green 557.7 nm at 100 km at the bottom, red 630 nm at 400 km at the top) decides how far above your horizon it reaches. **A low-latitude aurora is red because only the high red emission clears the horizon** — that is geometry, not a special case.

On the globe, NOAA's **OVATION** nowcast (the probability of aurora, from measured solar wind) is laid over it in colour. It is valid for about an hour either side, so moving the clock returns to the model's oval.

Below the panel are **Watching and photographing** and **How the aurora works** (mechanism, colour, the solar wind, the magnetosphere, space weather), each with links to its source.

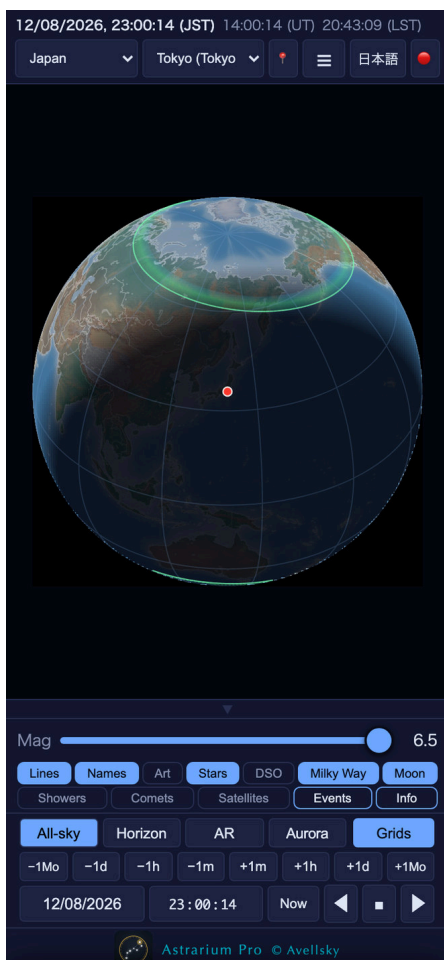


Figure 16. The aurora forecast, with the oval on the globe

11.4 The proper-motion time machine

Every star is moving through the galaxy on its own course. Press **Open** on the **PRO** tab and the slider carries the stars along that motion, forward or back, by up to **50,000 years**.

Open also switches the sky to the whole-sky view. What there is to see is the constellations losing their shape, and that only reads on a sky shown whole: the horizon view holds a handful of constellations, and over 50,000 years the ones you were watching swing below the horizon. If the satellite map or globe, the solar-system map or AR was up, it is folded away and the star chart comes back. If you are already on the whole sky, your projection and zoom are left alone.

While it is open, the clock at the top and the date on the bottom bar show that year too (the month, day and time stay as they are). **Back** returns both to the present. The clock itself has not moved: the time machine moves the stars, and the constellation lines and names that hang off them, while the Sun, the Moon and the planets stay where they are.

- Only the stars move, together with the constellation lines and names that hang off them. The clock does not move, so the Sun, the Moon and the planets stay where they are and the sky keeps turning as before.
- You can find, with your finger, the moment the Big Dipper stops being a dipper.
- **Now** restores the present sky, and so does reopening the app.

Precession is in it too

It is not only the stars that move. **The Earth's axis wanders** as well (precession), and the slider advances both — so **the celestial pole itself moves**.

- Now: Polaris, α Ursae Minoris
- In about 5,000 years: Alderamin, α Cephei
- In about 12,000 years: **Vega**, α Lyrae
- In about 26,000 years: round again to Polaris

The model is the **long-term precession** of Vondrák et al. (2011), built for $\pm 200,000$ years. The ordinary precession polynomials diverge past a few thousand, so they cannot carry a $\pm 50,000$ -year slider.

Precession outweighs proper motion here. Over 5,000 years a star's own motion is under a degree, while precession swings the whole sky by some 70° .

Type a year

The box under the slider takes a **calendar year**: 1800, 1800-05, -500. Press Go and the sky moves there.

Japanese era names come with it — 1800 reads 寛政12年, 1000 reads 平安時代 (the Heian period).

- Eras are listed from **Keicho (1596)** on; earlier years are answered with the name of the historical period instead. Better to name the period than to print an era we cannot vouch for.
- An era changes partway through its first year. This looks up by year, so **the year of a change reads as the newer era** (1868 is both Keio 4 and Meiji 1; it reads Meiji 1).
- **No era is given for future years.** When the next one begins, and what it will be called, is not decided.
- BCE uses the astronomical convention, which has a year 0: -500 is 501 BCE.

Time of day is not accepted: at the scale of proper motion not even a year is visible (Barnard's star, the fastest, moves 10 arcseconds a year).

Radial velocity and the Galaxy's gravity are in it

What moves the stars is a **numerical integration inside the Galactic potential** (added 2026-09-21). Both the star and the Sun are carried through the same potential, and the star is then looked at again from wherever the Sun has got to.

- **Radial velocity** — how fast a star approaches or recedes — is taken from the catalogue. **9,090 of the 9,096 BSC5 stars** have a measured value. It matters most for the near ones: including it moves Sirius (2.6 pc, -8 km/s) by about **400 arcseconds** at 10,000 years and **3 degrees** at 50,000. A star coming towards us grows its parallax, and its proper motion speeds up.
- **Galactic gravity** is included. The Sun and the star fall in slightly different directions (a tidal difference), which comes to **0.4–0.8 arcseconds** over 50,000 years. Small — but it is the largest systematic left once radial velocity is in, so fixing only one of the two would be half a job.
- The Galaxy model is a disc, a bulge and a halo, fitted so that **the local gradient of the potential matches the measurements** (circular speed 229 km/s, Oort A = 15.5 and B = -12.5 km/s/kpc, vertical frequency 76 km/s/kpc). Over 50,000 years that is the only part that shows.
- The integrator is time-reversible (leapfrog), so **running forward and back returns the original sky.**

Beyond 10,000 years it is still an approximation. What is left is the **parallax error** — the limit of the measurement itself. Fifty thousand years out, a 0.2 % error in Sirius's parallax moves it 10 arcseconds. Star-to-star gravity is not modelled either. **It is one possible arrangement, not a forecast**, and the app says so on screen.

Asterisms (the Spring Triangle, the Summer Triangle and so on) are hidden while the stars are moved: they are traced over today's arrangement, so they would be left hanging in empty sky.

11.5 The deep catalogue (more stars at telescope fields)

Zoom in past a 12° field and stars fainter than the naked eye appear. The source is **UCAC4** (US Naval Observatory, public domain); what is bundled is 37 MB of tiles down to $V < 12$.

Field width	Limiting magnitude
wider than 12°	not drawn (6.5 as usual)
down to 8°	10
down to 3°	11
down to 1°	12

Nothing is drawn at wide fields because nothing could be read. $V < 12$ is 57 stars per square degree; over the whole sky that is a grey haze. Zooming in is itself the key that opens this layer.

Only what is needed is read. The sky is cut into HEALPix cells (about 0.84 square degrees) and only the cells in view are fetched — move the field and a few new ones follow, a kilobyte each. No connection is required; it all happens on the device.

Faint stars can be tapped like any other, and give their UCAC4 number and magnitude.

11.6 Telling satellites apart

Colour carries the kind. The satellite list on the Sky tab shows the same colours as the chart.

Colour	Kind
Green	Space stations (ISS, Tiangong)
Gold	Brightest (visual)
Blue	Science
Violet	Weather
Blue-grey, small	Starlink
Orange	Just-launched Starlink (raising orbit)

Starlink markers are deliberately small. There are ten thousand of them in the catalogue; at the size of the others they fill the sky. Their names are not drawn either — tap one and it tells you.

Just-launched Starlink stands out on purpose. A fresh batch goes into a low orbit around 340 km in a train, and climbs to its operating altitude over some weeks. While it does, it is bright and moves in a line — the most conspicuous thing in the sky.

The test is “low orbit **and** from a recent launch”. Altitude alone is not enough: Starlink also lowers its orbit at end of life to burn up, so the low orbits hold **satellites on the way up and on the way down at the same time.**

The magnitude limit uses the best moment of the pass

The magnitude limit in the satellite panel is judged on **how bright the satellite gets at its best during the pass**, not on how bright it is right now.

A satellite just clearing the eastern horizon is far away and faint, and gains several magnitudes by the time it is overhead. Cut on the present brightness and a limit of 4 drops something that is “5th magnitude now”, only for it to appear out of nowhere a few minutes later — which reads as flickering. Judged on the peak, it **stays listed from rise to set.**

The list writes it as “5.6m → 3.5m”: the arrow says it is still brightening.

Night vision (●) keeps one colour. The red-only mode exists to protect dark adaptation; adding colour back would defeat it.

The globe shows altitude

On the globe each satellite is lifted off the surface by its altitude. The low-orbit swarm becomes a shell clinging to the ball; geostationary satellites hang well outside the limb. The kind of orbit is legible from the picture alone. The thin line marks the point on the ground directly below.

Up to 2000 km the height is to scale. **Above that it is compressed** — geostationary orbit is 5.6 Earth radii up, and at true scale it would fall outside the screen. The order of heights is preserved.

11.7 The solar system in 3D

The Sun at the centre, the planets and their orbits placed in space.

You move it with your fingers (or the mouse).

- **Drag** to turn: left and right swing round, up and down change how far you look down on the plane. This is how the **inclinations** show.
- **Pinch or scroll** to zoom.
- “Reset the view” returns to looking straight down.

The Sun always stays at the centre. There is no panning: once the centre of a solar-system map drifts, it stops being clear what you are looking at from where. Turning and closing in are the only two moves.

The sliders are still there: when you want exactly face-on, a number is quicker than a finger.

Choosing what to show

The switches run in the same order as the sky chart's.

Stars and the Milky Way	the background sky (5,080 stars to 6th magnitude, and the panorama)
Constellation names	names on the background — they say which way you are facing
Constellation figures	the artwork, laid faintly behind
Sun and planets	the Sun, the planets and their orbits
Sun and planet names	the labels only (the bodies stay)
Small bodies	asteroids and comets

Names and figures start switched off. Laid over a solar-system map they put the orbits and the small bodies underneath them; switch them on when you want to know which way the view is pointing.

Stars and the Milky Way behind

The background carries the stars **down to 6th magnitude (5,080 of them)**, the constellation lines, and the Milky Way — the same NASA Deep Star Maps

panorama the sky chart uses.

It is drawn in perspective, so the sky fills the frame — you are inside the solar system looking out. The background turns with the view: seen from here the sky is infinitely far away, so it is placed by direction rather than by position. Turn towards the galactic centre and the star clouds and dust lanes come up in front of you.

Star sizes, brightness and the way the constellation lines are drawn follow Meteorium, the same author's meteor application. **The Milky Way itself is kept dimmer here**, though: there the sky is the subject, while here the solar system sits in front of it, and at the same brightness the orbits and small bodies drown in the white haze.

Small bodies

The bundled small bodies are drawn **coloured by dynamical group**.

Red, orange, pink, violet	Near-Earth families (Apollo, Amor, Aten, Atira)
Three blue-greys	Main belt: inner, middle, outer (split at the 3:1 and 5:2 Kirkwood gaps)
Yellow	Hildas (3:2 with Jupiter)
Green	Jupiter Trojans (1:1 — they gather 60° ahead of and behind Jupiter)
Cyan	Centaur
Pink	Plutinos (3:2 with Neptune — Pluto's companions)
Mauve	Classical Kuiper belt (cubewanos)
Light violet	Twotinos (2:1 with Neptune)
Deep violet	Scattered disc (perihelion within Neptune's reach)
Sky blue	Detached objects (Sedna and the like)
White	Dwarf planets (Ceres, Pluto, Eris, Haumea, Makemake)
Pale amber	Dwarf-planet candidates (Quaoar, Sedna, Orcus — 27 of them)
Teal	Comets

The trans-Neptunian objects are split four ways by dynamics. As one group, the bodies that keep step with Neptune (the plutinos), the ones it threw

outward (the scattered disc) and the ones it cannot reach (the detached objects) all lay in one colour, though they were born in different places and live in different ones.

Dwarf planets are drawn larger and named. There are only 5 and 27 of them, but they are the best-known bodies on the map; at one pixel you could not tell they were there. Their names follow the “Sun and planet names” switch.

The boundaries and colours match Asterion, the same author’s other application, so that one solar system does not need to be read two ways. Any group can be switched off in the legend.

The whole MPC catalogue is bundled — 1,553,211 asteroids. The source is MPCORB (the Minor Planet Center Orbit Database): everything from the numbered objects down to the recent one-opposition ones, wherever the MPC judges a reasonable prediction possible. Comets (951) are not in MPCORB, so those still come from the bundled JPL SBDB set.

The slider (0–100 %) is the share of the catalogue that is drawn, and 100 % is all of it. The row under the slider reads “drawn / carried”.

Drawing all 1.5 million costs about **a second to solve and a tenth to plot** on the development machine (it is solved again whenever the clock moves), and several times that on a phone. If it feels heavy, pull the slider down — 10 % is still 150,000 points, enough to read the belt’s texture and the Kirkwood gaps.

Every group is taken brightest-first, so thinning leaves a clean cut: everything above some magnitude is present. Small groups — the Atiras are 39 objects — are never divided by the budget, or they would vanish.

Fast-forward thins them automatically. Standing still, density is the point (the belt’s texture, the Kirkwood gaps); moving, the motion is the point, and every frame has to be solved again.

The small bodies move with the clock too. What arrives is orbital elements rather than positions, and the display solves Kepler’s equation for each moment. Fast-forward and you watch the belt turn faster on the inside than on the outside — Kepler’s third law, straight off the screen.

The planets and the spacecraft move too

A planet slides along the ellipse you can see. It arrives as orbital elements rather than a position and is solved like any small body; the orbit line comes from the same state, so a planet never drifts off its own line.

It is a two-body solution, so the further the clock goes the further it departs from the truth (measured: 0.04 au for the Earth ten years out — about two pixels here). Once the clock is half a year from the anchor, the planets alone are fetched again and re-anchored.

The bundled ephemeris (DE421) covers 1899–2053. Outside that there is nothing to re-anchor against, so the map keeps going two-body from the last anchor: better slightly wrong and moving than stopped.

Spacecraft follow the path they actually flew, sampled from Horizons and read off by date — **including ahead of now**: an active craft is fetched three years into the future (or as far as Horizons goes). A finished flight stops at its last point (Cassini in 2017, Rosetta in 2016).

How time moves here

While the map is open, one day is the smallest step. A minute or an hour moves nothing at this scale (0.04° for the Earth, 0.003° for Jupiter), so those buttons would do nothing. Fast-forward starts at a day per second and climbs by week, month and half-year. Back on the sky chart, minutes and hours behave as before.

Fetching it all in advance

Download from JPL (SBDB) fetches the paths of all 17 spacecraft, plus any small bodies you have added, and keeps them on the device. **The next time you open the map no connection is needed** — the button is for pressing before you go somewhere without a signal.

It reports how many were kept. Device storage has a limit, so if some did not fit it says how many. Normally there is no need to press it: a spacecraft is fetched when you tick it.

What you can add from JPL

Spacecraft (tick one and it appears — **35 of them**)

The list runs **in order of launch**, from Mariner 2 (1962) to Europa Clipper (2024): read it top to bottom and it is the history of solar system exploration. The launch year is shown beside each name.

1960s–70s

Mariner 2, Pioneer 10 and 11, Voyager
1 and 2

1980s–90s	Galileo, Ulysses, NEAR Shoemaker, Cassini, Nozomi, Stardust
2000s	Genesis, Hayabusa, Rosetta, MESSENGER, Deep Impact, New Horizons, Dawn
2010s	Akatsuki, Juno, MAVEN, Hayabusa2, OSIRIS-REx, Parker, BepiColombo
2020s	Solar Orbiter, Perseverance, Lucy, DART, James Webb, EQUULEUS, JUICE, Psyche, Hera, Europa Clipper

Press the name, or the dot on the map, and the spacecraft describes itself: a photograph, the launch date, and the span over which its path can be drawn. The text is the opening of the Wikipedia article (CC BY-SA 4.0) and the photograph comes from Wikimedia Commons — free licences only. The attribution is printed on the card.

The span is not the same as the launch. It is what JPL Horizons holds:

- **Hayabusa** begins only in January 2009. The cruise from the 2003 launch out to Itokawa and back is not published, so what can be drawn is the final leg home. Add Itokawa as a small body (25143) and the journey still reads.
- **Rosetta** ends in October 2016 (it landed on the comet) and **Cassini** in September 2017 (it was flown into Saturn).
- Ulysses, Dawn, DART, NEAR and Perseverance are cut off here even though Horizons goes further: the spacecraft no longer exists, and drawing a prediction of where the wreckage would be as “where it is now” would be a lie.

Viking and Magellan cannot be shown. They are not in the Horizons spacecraft list (their names return asteroids instead). Of the 1970s missions, only the Pioneers, the Voyagers and Mariner 2 still have an ephemeris there.

11.8 Two more kinds of event

The Events tab holds two more kinds (the range and direction are the same as in the free version).

- **Exoplanet transits** — the transits observable from your site.
- **Variable stars** — predicted maxima and minima of the main variables.

Pressing a row moves the clock to that moment and **marks the target and centres it** on the chart.

12. If something looks wrong

Location does not work

Settings → Privacy & Security → Location Services, and set Astrarium to “While Using the App”. You can also skip location altogether and type coordinates into the Info tab.

The event list is slow

Only the first 5- or 10-year scan, which takes a few minutes. It is cached afterwards.

The aurora forecast will not load

It needs a connection. Without one, the Kp slider still shows what a storm would look like — that part is computed on the device. **No comets appear** The Comets button shows nothing when no comet is brighter than the limit, and fetching current elements needs a connection.

No meteor rate is shown

You are more than a day from the maximum, or outside the activity period. The rate is also zero in daylight.

Too few or too many stars

Move the magnitude-limit slider. To match a real sky, a city is about 4, the suburbs 5-something, and a dark mountain site 6.5.

No satellites appear

Either the orbital elements (TLEs) have never been downloaded, or playback is faster than $\times 600$. With “Sunlit only” ticked, craft in the Earth’s shadow are hidden.

TLEs will not download, or the address has been blocked

Celestrak answers a caller that fetches the same group more often than every two hours with an error, and blocks the **IP address** if it continues. The block is against the connection, not against your device or Apple ID, so:

1. Stop fetching and leave it alone for a while. Astrarium Pro does not touch the network within two hours of a fetch, so ordinary use will not get you blocked.
2. Switching networks (Wi-Fi to mobile data, or the other way) changes the address and often works. On shared Wi-Fi the cause may be someone else on the same connection.
3. If it does not clear, ask Celestrak (celestrak.org) to lift it.

While blocked, **the elements you have already fetched still work**. They lose accuracy over a few days, but the chart and the pass predictions keep running without a connection.

The event list is slow

Only the first 5- or 10-year scan, which takes a few minutes. It runs in the background and fills in when it finishes; the result is cached, so the next one

is immediate.

In AR the chart does not line up with the sky

Steel-framed buildings and cars upset the compass. Step outside and press **Reset**, or correct it by hand with the **bearing** slider.

13. Glossary

Term	Meaning
Magnitude	Brightness; smaller is brighter, and one magnitude is a factor of about 2.5
Azimuth / altitude	Direction round the horizon (north 0°, east 90°) and angle above it
RA / Dec	Coordinates fixed to the sky — the system star catalogues use
Local sidereal time	The right ascension currently on the meridian
Universal Time	Time at longitude 0°
Moon age	Days since new Moon; 0 is new, about 14.8 is full
Illumination	The fraction of the Moon's disc that is lit
Airmass	Thickness of atmosphere, 1 at the zenith; the larger, the worse the seeing
ZHR	Meteors per hour with the radiant overhead and a 6.5-magnitude sky
Radiant	The point the meteors of a shower appear to come from
TLE	A satellite's orbital elements; they go stale in a few days and need refreshing
Kp	The index of geomagnetic disturbance (0–9); the higher it is, the further the auroral oval reaches towards the equator
Geomagnetic latitude	Latitude measured from the geomagnetic pole — what the aurora actually follows

14. Credits and contact

Every source Astrarium Pro computes from is listed in the app under **Info** → **Credits and sources**. The principal ones are:

- Planetary ephemeris: JPL DE421
- Stars: Yale Bright Star Catalogue, Tycho-2
- Deep sky: the Messier and Caldwell catalogues; photographs from Wikimedia Commons (freely licensed images only)
- Satellites: Celestrak (TLEs), SGP4/SDP4
- Space weather: NASA DONKI (solar wind, geomagnetic storms), NOAA SWPC OVATION (aurora probability)
- Comets and asteroids: Minor Planet Center, JPL Small-Body Database
- Earth orientation: IERS finals2000A

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